

"the" & "a"

Quick Reference Guide

Factors	The	A, an	[none] Some/"Silent Some"	[none] Possessive Noun/Pronoun	Examples	Comments
Focus of comment	narrow	broad		o	The: Please focus on the tunnel of light. A: France is a nation among many. Possessive: They are our friends.	
Group size	small	big		o	A: Please show him a painting. The: Please show him the Van Gogh.	
Number in existence	only one exists (in the context)	many exist (in the context)	(substitute for "some")	o	The: This is the Milky Way Galaxy. A: The is a grain of sand.	
Specialness	o	x	x	o	The: Naoto Kan was the prime minister. A: This is a goldfish.	
Mentioned already or not	already mentioned	not already mentioned	not already mentioned	already mentioned	A: A team of researchers in Belarus... The: The researchers found that....	
Countability	Uncountable - Specific	Countable	Uncountable - General (substitute for "some")	o	The: I'll have the red house wine, please. A: I'll have a cup. Silent "some": I'll have wine.	
Description: noun property quantitative/qualitative adj	quantitative noun quantity/quality e.g. height: 3cm	adjective quality e.g. tall	o	o	The: Can you tell me the height? A: Please give me a tall one. silent "some": I need (some) more length. silent "some": We need (some) tall kids.	Exception: trumped by identification.
Descriptive phrase: "it is _____ inexpensive X."	identifying (Which is it? it's the... [unless items not on hand])	describing (or identifying items not on hand)	o	o	These shoes are a little (bit) too tight (just) here." Was the green shirt a high quality shirt? Was the green shirt a low quality one? silent "some": They are inexpensive shoes. Identifying something very specific: A: Yes, I want the blue pair of shoes.	When specifying one present option, "the" may replace the normal pattern. Here "the" has the same meaning as "this," or "these"
Singular or Plural	plural	single	o	o	The: These are the three pens. A: This is a pen.	
Unit-Groups (pair, dozen)	x	o	x	o	A: I want a pair of shoes.	Exception: trumped by identification.
specific identification:	o	x	x	o	A: Yes, I want the blue pair of shoes.	

Table 1: Factors

"the" & "a"

"The" & "A" The Rule of The Silent "Some"

A Quick-Reference Guide

Version 1 - The rule of the silent "some":

If you can say "some,"
then you can use no-word.

Example: I am watching some TV. = I am watching TV.

Version 2 - The rule of the silent "some":

General references to uncountable things often have no word, very specific references often use "the":

Examples:

I am drinking water.	= I am drinking some water.
I am watching TV.	= I am watching some TV.
I am buying snacks.	= I am buying some snacks.
I am making dinner.	= I am making some dinner.
I am having wine.	= I am having some wine.
I am meeting with friends.	= I am meeting with some friends.

Version 3 - The rule of the silent "some":

In most cases, when a "the" or "a" is not used,
it was replaced by a silent "some,"
unless it was replaced by a possessive noun or pronoun (or demonstrative pronoun).

Examples:

Normal	=	the/a	=	Please give me the tea.
No-word	=	Silent "some"	=	Please give me () tea.
			=	Please give me (some) tea.

or

Please give me John's tea.
Please give me her tea.
Please give me this/that tea.